Seward oversaw the signing of a more expansive treaty with China in 1868, and advocated for the annexation of the Hawaiian kingdom and the building of the Panama Canal. In terms of actual territorial expansion, Seward was less successful, known for purchasing Alaska, but only the small atoll of Midway, claimed in 1867, marked any absorption of Pacific islands.[17] Seward was decades ahead of his time, however, for not until 1898 did the United States become the type of colonial power envisioned by the most passionate expansionists. Fueled by concepts of maritime supremacy popularized by Alfred Thayer Mahan and promoted by policy makers such as Theodore Roosevelt and Henry Cabot Lodge, US forces annexed Hawaii, invaded and captured the Philippines, and took over Guam and part of Samoa, all in 1898–99. In one fell swoop, America overturned nearly a century of tradition and became one of the leading colonial powers in the Pacific. The new imperial policy collapsed the long-standing "zone of influence" into the "zone of control," thereby unifying American action across the Pacific, from the western coast of the United States all the way to the Philippines. From 1898 on, despite its limited power, the United States envisioned the Pacific Ocean, up to Chinese and Japanese waters, as a zone of control through its naval presence and string of territories reaching nearly to the Asian littoral. Only after 1945 would Washington consider all of Asia proper to be within a zone of control designed to prevent the emergence of any other hegemonic military power in the region, and to keep the Pacific "free and open."

Yet even with this broader orientation, US strategy continued to lag expansion. Despite the growing shadow of Japanese power after its defeat of China in 1895 and Russia in 1905, Washington's thinking in the early twentieth century was limited to relatively modest, and insufficient, planning for defending America's far-flung possessions. Other than the US Navy's War Plan Orange, there was little, if any, discussion about how to maintain stability in the Indo-Pacific.[18] Inertia in strategic planning came from the complexity of dealing with the multiple spheres of influence of the region's colonial powers, as well as the presumption that the Washington and London naval arms limitation